POLS 1002
Introduction to Global Politics

INSTRUCTOR Zachary Sedefian

Course Description

This course introduces numerous frameworks through which a systemic understanding of contemporary global politics can be developed. It covers topics including the uses of power, the role of the state, political economy, globalization, development, transnational movements, international organizations, and the causes of domination, exploitation, and war from a materialist perspective. Critical approaches include class, race, gender, belief, anti-colonial, language-cultural, and others.

The course is divided into four units:

a) foundations and theory, covering historical and contemporary debates in global politics to build a conceptual framework for the course

b) the global politics of historical capitalism, establishing a framework for understanding political change across five hundred years of social history up to today

c) case studies in revolution and counter-revolution, with units focusing on the global impacts of the Haitian, Russian, and Chinese revolutions, as well as the Cold War

d) analyses of contemporary political movements and their ideologies in the West, Russia, and China, with a focus on the role of media and propaganda to understand what some scholars describe as a New Cold War

This is a reading and discussion-based course. Classics in the field of political science will be closely studied alongside primary documents of revolutionary leaders and critical texts by male and female authors from Africa, Latin America, the Middle East, Eastern Europe, Asia, and North America. The course is designed to enable students to develop analytical skills necessary for critically engaging with media and scholarship, and for understanding contemporary political events in a constantly transforming world.

Student Learning Outcomes

CUNY Pathways, Flexible Core: World Cultures & Global Issues

This course will offer you a chance to consider these questions from the perspective of political science, as well as satisfy CUNY and Brooklyn College's Pathways Flexible Core "World Cultures & Global Issues" requirement. By the end of the course, you will be able to do the following:

Flexible Core

- Gather, interpret, and assess information from a variety of sources and points of view.
- Evaluate evidence and arguments critically and analytically.
- Produce well-reasoned written or oral arguments using evidence to support conclusions.

World Cultures & Global Issues

- Identify and apply the fundamental concepts and methods of political science in exploring global issues.
- Analyze globalization and describe an event or process from more than one point of view.
- Analyze the historical development of one or more non-U.S. societies.
- Analyze the significance of one or more major movements that have shaped the world's societies.
- Analyze and discuss the role that race, ethnicity, class, gender, language, sexual orientation, belief, or other forms of social differentiation play in world cultures or societies.

Political Science Outcomes

- Recognize and explain key political concepts (such as "power," "ideology," and "the state").
- Recognize the multiple theories of power that shape the discipline of political science and employ them to explain the workings of key political institutions, actors, movements, and events across the discipline and in applied settings.

Class Expectations

- Attentive and critical reading is key to success in the course. There is no textbook cost; readings appear on Brightspace.
- Attendance is key. You may miss one class without penalty; each absence after that lowers your participation grade. Please notify me by email in case of absexnce. There is no review class, and all material will be covered in exams.
- When emailing me, please begin the subject line with "POLS 1002" to keep it from getting buried. I usually reply within one business day.
- Written assignments must be completed in APA format or Chicago author-date.
- A respectful classroom environment is key to education. Please adhere to students' names, pronouns, and other preferences. Politics can be a personal topic. One aim of political science is to develop an objective, impartial, and scientific understanding of events that occur between groups of people. This is why the purpose of class discussion is to enable students to sharpen their analytical and rhetorical skills by exploring a variety of perspectives, including those that they don't agree with. When you hear a perspective you don't agree with, address the evidence and reasoning without reference to a person's character or supposed motivation.

Assignments

WT.	ASSESSMENT	DUE	NOTES
20%	Participation	Ongoing	Reading discussion
10%	Reading quizzes	Each class	Multiple-choice
15%	Midterm exam	Oct. 20	Short response
15%	Essay 1	Oct. 9	800–1000 words
20%	Essay 2	Dec. 1	1200–1500 words
20%	Final exam	Dec. 16	Short response + essay

20% Participation

Students are expected to attend class having completed the assigned readings before each session so that they can actively follow the lecture and discussion. Students are not expected to have mastered the readings, but to come to class familiar with the key concepts, arguments, and evidence of the readings (or videos). This way, students can ask questions, raise points of confusion, and engage in discussion.

I will post discussion questions on Brightspace in advance of each session. Come ready to answer them, as we will work through them together in class. They are the best study material for the exams and essays.

Participation includes bringing reading assignments to each class to reference. BC offers free on-campus printing, or you can use a tablet or laptop. Digital devices can be a distraction, so please use them only for class purposes.

It's also important that you keep up with current events to aid our discussions. For example, CUNY gives you free access to mainstream sources like *The New York Times* and *The Wall Street Journal*, and *Democracy Now!* posts a fifteen-minute daily headline show on YouTube which can be a great discussion prompt. For critical media, visit The Grayzone, Breakthrough News, or Covert Action Magazine.

10% Reading Quizzes

One multiple-choice quiz on the readings per class will be given on Brightspace. They are designed to take one to five minutes to answer for students who have studied the reading assignments. They will become available on Brightspace at the start of the week and will be due by 8AM Tuesday/Thursday. In total, 25 quizzes will be given (no quiz for Sept. 1 or the Oct. 20 midterm), and the lowest 5 will be dropped.

15% Midterm Exam

Short response format questions based on concepts and examples from the readings and class. They will likely be heavily based on the reading questions, so it is important you respond to them in your notes.

15% Essay 1, Comparative Analysis

Using at least one example each from Rodney's *How Europe Underdeveloped Africa* and Nkrumah's *Neo-Colonialism*, explain how one political economy mechanism (e.g., primitive accumulation, slavery and forced labor, plunder and resource extraction, political/cultural/educational domination, etc.) worked under colonial rule and how it works after formal independence. What changed, and what did not? Hint: follow one industry (agriculture, mining, banking) and trace

where the commodities and the profits go. Cite at least one other reading. 800–1000 words, or around 3–4 pages of text (excluding references), in APA student format or Chicago author-date. Submit to Brightspace by **Oct. 9, 11:59 PM**.

20% Essay 2, Film Review

Apply any major concept from class to one of the films from the list. The opening of the essay can briefly summarize the plot and the background of the film and director, but the purpose of the essay is not to summarize the film. For example, analyze whether and how concepts like settler colonialism apply to *No Other Land*, neo-colonialism to *Lumumba*, propaganda to *The Revolution Will Not Be Televised*, interventionism to *Soundtrack to a Coup d'État* or *The Act of Killing*, and globalization or underdevelopment to *Darwin's Nightmare*. There are many such combinations, and feel free to answer in the negative if you find the concept does not apply fully or partially. 1200–1500 words (5–6 pages). Cite at least three class readings. Cite the film using timestamps. Not all can be found for free, but I've provided some links below. Submit to Brightspace by **Dec. 1, 11:59 PM**.

- The Young Karl Marx
- The Battle of Algiers
- The Act of Killing
- The Hour of the Furnaces, I
- Soundtrack to a Coup d'État
- The Coconut Revolution
- Lumumba
- Thomas Sankara: Upright Man
- Darwin's Nightmare
- The Revolution Will Not Be Televised
- Why We Fight
- No Other Land

20% Final Exam

Same format as the midterm exam, plus short essay. Essay topics distributed in advance. Both the midterm and the final are taken in person. Note that the final falls on Dec. 16, a Wednesday, during the College's final-examination period — not on our usual Tuesday/Thursday schedule.

Grading Scale

GRADE	RANGE	GRADE	RANGE	GRADE	RANGE
A+	97–100%	B–	80–82.99%	D	63–66.99%
A	93–96.99%	C+	77–79.99%	D–	60–62.99%
A–	90–92.99%	C	73–76.99%	F	0–59.99%
B+	87–89.99%	C–	70–72.99%		
B	83–86.99%	D+	67–69.99%		

Final Grade Submission: Dec. 28. Your final grade will reflect the cumulative sum of the grade breakdowns above. Grades are assigned on the scale above; this course is not graded on a curve.

Drafts and Rewrites

For Essay 1 and Essay 2, you may submit a draft up to one week before the due date and I will return comments in time for you to revise. Graded essays may not be rewritten for a new grade, and quizzes and exams may not be retaken. No late submissions.

Generative AI

Generative AI may not be used to produce text you submit. That includes summarizing a reading you have not read. It is acceptable to use spell-check and grammar tools such as Grammarly on sentences that you wrote yourself, or look up basic definitions (with heavy skepticism). More details on this policy will be distributed in a separate document.

College and University Policies

Academic Integrity

The faculty and administration of Brooklyn College support an environment free from cheating and plagiarism. Each student is responsible for being aware of what constitutes cheating and plagiarism and for avoiding both. The complete text of the CUNY Academic Integrity Policy can be found at www.brooklyn.edu/policies. If a faculty member suspects a violation of academic integrity and, upon investigation, confirms that violation, or if the student admits the violation, the faculty member MUST report the violation. Students should be aware that faculty may use plagiarism detection software.

Center for Student Disability Services

In order to receive disability-related academic accommodations students must first be registered with the Center for Student Disability Services (CSDS). Students who have a documented disability or suspect they may have a disability (physical or mental condition which substantially limits one or more major life activity) are invited to call the Center at (718) 951-5538 or visit 138 Roosevelt Hall. If you have already registered with the CSDS and submitted necessary forms, you will receive your course accommodation letter to provide to your professor and these specific accommodations can be discussed when appropriate.

Sex-Based Misconduct, Discrimination, and Title IX

Brooklyn College is committed to fostering a safe, equitable and productive learning environment. Someone experiencing any form of prohibited discrimination or sexual misconduct, on or off campus, can find information about how to make a report, their rights, confidential resources, supportive measures, and reporting obligations of Brooklyn College employees on the Office of Diversity and Equity website.

Reports should be made to Danielle Haynes, Chief Diversity Officer, or Michelle Mendez, Title IX Coordinator (both 718.951.4128), and may also be made to Public Safety (718.951.5511) or the NYPD (911). All Brooklyn College and CUNY policies apply whether conduct occurs on campus, off campus, or virtually.

Zoom Sessions: Cameras and Recording

Thursday sessions meet on Zoom, using the same link all semester. Registered students will find the join link, passcode, and calendar invite on Brightspace. Exams are in person. I prefer cameras be on for most of the discussion for other students' sake.

Recording class sessions without my advance written consent is not permitted, and recordings may not be distributed. Students with a CSDS accommodation permitting recording should present the accommodation letter in advance. If I record a session, I will tell you beforehand.

Registered students will find the link and calendar invite on Brightspace.

Religious Observance

New York State Education Law (Title I, Article 5, §224-a) entitles students who are absent because of religious beliefs to an equivalent opportunity to make up any examination, study, or work requirement missed on account of that absence. If a religious observance conflicts with a class meeting, an exam, or a due date in this syllabus, notify me in advance and we will arrange an alternative. See the front matter of the Undergraduate Bulletin for the full policy.

Bereavement

Students who experience the death of an immediate family member should consult the Brooklyn College Student Bereavement Policy, which provides for an excused absence and arrangements to complete missed work. Please contact me as soon as you are able.

Student Support

OFFICE	CONTACT
Personal Counseling Center	0203 James Hall · 718.951.5363
Health Clinic	114 Roosevelt Hall · 718.951.5580
Immigrant Student Success	117 Roosevelt Hall · 718.951.5023
LGBTQ+ Resource Center	219 Student Center · 718.951.5739
Women's Center	227 Ingersoll Hall Ext. · 718.951.5777
Brooklyn College Library	library.brooklyn.cuny.edu

For anything else, the "Hand Raise" button in Navigate routes you to advisement, technology help, emergency grants, food and housing assistance, and health services.

Semester Calendar

Tuesdays are in person; Thursdays are on Zoom, with the exception of Oct. 15. Both exams are taken in person. See the Fall 2026 academic calendar for college-wide dates.

WEEK	TUESDAY	THURSDAY
1. Aug. 30–Sept. 5	Sept. 1 in person	Sept. 3 online
2. Sept. 6–12	Sept. 8 in person	Sept. 10 online
3. Sept. 13–19	Sept. 15 in person	Sept. 17 online
4. Sept. 20–26	Sept. 22 in person	Sept. 24 online
5. Sept. 27–Oct. 3	Sept. 29 in person	Oct. 1 online
6. Oct. 4–10	Oct. 6 in person	Oct. 8 online
Oct. 9	**Essay 1 due** 11:59 PM	
7. Oct. 11–17	*no class (Monday schedule)*	Oct. 15 **in person**
8. Oct. 18–24	Oct. 20 **midterm**	Oct. 22 online
9. Oct. 25–31	Oct. 27 in person	Oct. 29 online
10. Nov. 1–7	Nov. 3 in person	Nov. 5 online
Nov. 2	Black Solidarity Day (Monday — no exams or special events)	
Nov. 6	**Last day to withdraw with a "W" grade**	
11. Nov. 8–14	Nov. 10 in person	Nov. 12 online
12. Nov. 15–21	Nov. 17 in person	Nov. 19 online
12B. Nov. 22–28	Nov. 24 in person	*no class (Thanksgiving)*
13. Nov. 29–Dec. 5	Dec. 1 in person	Dec. 3 online
Dec. 1	**Essay 2 due** 11:59 PM	
14. Dec. 6–12	Dec. 8 in person	Dec. 10 online
Dec. 15–21	**Final exams** (ours is Dec. 16)	
Dec. 21	End of fall term	

Class Structure

The readings are a mix of theoretical and empirical accounts of a variety of political science subjects across the fields of international relations, political theory, comparative politics, and political economy. They come from a variety of critical perspectives and are intended to interrogate common sense beliefs and provoke critical thinking. Just because a text is assigned does not mean it is the only, or the correct, perspective. Reading/discussion questions are meant to help you understand the author's argument on their own terms.

Readings and Assignment Schedule

UNIT I Theory Basics

WEEK 01 Politics as a Historical and Global System — Sept. 1 & 3

Sept. 1
- "Capitalism," *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, §§1.1–1.2, 2.3, 3.3–3.6. 2026 — 8 pp.

Sept. 3
- James Madison, *Terms of the Senate*, June 26. 1787 — 6 pp.
- Karl Marx & Friedrich Engels, *Manifesto of the Communist Party*, I. 1848 — 14 pp.

WEEK 02 Class, State, and Hegemony — Sept. 8 & 10

Sept. 8
- Veltmeyer & Delgado Wise, *Critical Development Studies*, selections. 2018 — 14 pp.
- V. I. Lenin, *The State and Revolution*, ch. 1, "Class Society and the State." 1917 — 16 pp.

Sept. 10
- Michael Parenti, *Inventing Reality*, ch. 1. 1986 — 28 pp.

WEEK 03 Modern International Relations — Sept. 15 & 17

Sept. 15
- John Smith, *Imperialism in the Twenty-First Century*, ch. I. 2016 — 29 pp.

Sept. 17
- Immanuel Wallerstein, *World-Systems Analysis*, ch. 3. 2004 — 18 pp.

UNIT II Historical Capitalism

WEEK 04 Development and Underdevelopment — Sept. 22 & 24

Sept. 22
- Marx, *Capital*, vol. 1, ch. 26, "The Secret of Primitive Accumulation." 1867 — 6 pp.
- Walter Rodney, *How Europe Underdeveloped Africa*, ch. 1. 1972 — 25 pp.

Sept. 24
- Rodney, *How Europe Underdeveloped Africa*, ch. 5, pp. 149–178. 1972 — 30 pp.

WEEK 05 Globalization in the Post-War Era — Sept. 29 & Oct. 1

Sept. 29
- Joseph Stiglitz, *Globalization and Its Discontents*, ch. 5 (skim ch. 6). 2002 — 33 pp.

Oct. 1
- Kwame Nkrumah, *Neo-Colonialism*, intro. and ch. 1. 1965 — 19 pp.

WEEK 06 Political Change in National Liberation and Women's Liberation — Oct. 6 & 8

Oct. 6
- Suzy Kim, "Dispelling Myths about North Korea" (video). 2016 — 26 min.
- Suzy Kim, *Everyday Life in the North Korean Revolution*, intro. 2013 — 13 pp.

Oct. 8 Suzy Kim, *Everyday Life in the North Korean Revolution*, ch. 6, "Revolutionary Motherhood." 2013 . . . . . 29 pp.

DUE **Essay 1** **Oct. 9, 11:59 PM**

WEEK 07 Political Violence in Colonialism and Anti-colonialism

Oct. 15

Oct. 13 *No class (Monday schedule)*

Oct. 15 IN PERSON

Frantz Fanon, *The Wretched of the Earth*, "On Violence," pp. 1–52. 1961 . . . . . 52 pp.

UNIT III Revolution and Counter-Revolution

WEEK 08 The Haitian Revolution

Oct. 20 & 22

Oct. 20 MIDTERM EXAM No reading or quiz

Oct. 22 C. L. R. James, *The Black Jacobins*, intro., chs. 1 & 4. 1938 . . . . . 47 pp.

WEEK 09 The Russian Revolution and the Third World

Oct. 27 & 29

Oct. 27 Vijay Prashad, *Red Star Over the Third World*, preface through "Follow the Path of the Russians!" 2017 . . . . . 30 pp.

Oct. 29 Prashad, *The Darker Nations*, "Bandung." 2007 . . . . . 20 pp.

OPTIONAL Prashad, *Red Star Over the Third World*, "Colonial Fascism."

WEEK 10 US Cold War on the Third World

Nov. 3 & 5

Nov. 3 William Blum, *Killing Hope*, intro., chs. 1—2, 4–5. 2003 . . . . . 37 pp.

Nov. 5 Blum, *Killing Hope*, chs. 52, 55–56. 2003 . . . . . 41 pp.

UNIT IV Contemporary Political Movements

WEEK 11 Liberal Universalism: There is No Alternative

Nov. 10 & 12

Nov. 10 Alfred de Zayas, *The Human Rights Industry*, preface, ch. 6. 2023 . . . . . 40 pp.

United Nations, Universal Declaration of Human Rights. 1948 . . . . . 4 pp.

Nov. 12 Benjamin & Davies, *NATO: What You Need to Know*, selections. 2024 . . . . . 30 pp.

WEEK 12 Reactionary Politics: Far-Right, Ultranationalism, Fascism — Nov. 17 & 19

Nov. 17 Roger Griffin, ed., *International Fascism*, selections. 1998 . . . . . 27 pp.

Nov. 19 Lindsey O'Rourke, *Covert Regime Change*, ch. 6. 2018 . . . . . 6 pp.
Ivan Katchanovski, *The Russia-Ukraine War and Its Origins*, ch. 11. 2026 . . . . 16 pp.

WEEK 12B The Western Left: Social Democracy Today — Nov. 24

Nov. 24 Torkil Lauesen, *Riding the Wave: Sweden's Imperialism*, selections. 2021 . . . . . 31 pp.

Nov. 26 *No class (Thanksgiving — college closed)*

WEEK 13 Post-Liberal Politics: Civilizationism in Russia — Dec. 1 & 3

DUE **Essay 2 Dec. 1**

Dec. 1 Samir Amin, *Eurocentrism*, preface and ch. 3, §§1–4. 1988 . . . . . 15 pp.
Nikolai Petro, "Are We Reading Russia Right?" 2018 . . . . . 16 pp.

Dec. 3 Paul Robinson, *Russia's World Order*, intro., ch. 7, and conclusion. 2026 . . . . 31 pp.

WEEK 14 Socialism with Chinese Characteristics for a New Era — Dec. 8 & 10

Dec. 8 Roland Boer, *Socialism with Chinese Characteristics*, preface and ch. 1. 2021 . . 22 pp.

Dec. 10 Boer, "The Concrete Conditions of Human Rights: Western and Chinese." 2021 16 pp.

Reading assignments are subject to change.